Marrowdeep — Region Moods & Pre-Art Notes

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How each region of Acts I and II should feel, plus the Act III summoner idea, agreed before generating any mood-board art. Companion to the Story Bible & Storyboard v2.

Act I: the road home

Act I runs grasslands → swamp → desert → mountains → border fort, and each region has one feeling it never breaks.

1. Grasslands: "too quiet"

Dawn meadows, dew, long grass moving, standing stones, a white sun through mist. Beautiful, and wrong:

- crows that don't fly when you pass;
- scarecrows that face you a frame later;
- sheep lying in the grass, untouched;
- no birdsong, just wind.

Palette: pale gold, grey-green, bone white, one red thing per screen. **Foes:** scarecrows, crows, bounty riders, warhounds.

2. Swamp: horror

Black water, hanging moss, stilt huts, bog bodies half-sunk with faces up, leeches on everything, a drowned chapel bell. Flooded floors slow you, and hands grab from the water.

Palette: sickly green, black, bruise purple. **Foes:** Fen Hags, Bog Drowners, Marsh Lanterns (wisps that lure you into bogs), leech swarms.

3. Desert: what's left of Kesh

The desert is the land the brothers burned in the prologue: salted earth, sand over the bones of the war, half-buried siege towers, the ribs of granaries, glass where the fire was hottest. It explains why there's a desert between a swamp and mountains, and the player

walks through their own war crime.

- **Mechanics:** wind gusts (the ash environment already has them), sandstorms that cut visibility, sand sliding off ledges.
- **Foes:** salt wraiths (Kesh's dead), buried soldiers rising, vultures, sand-dragged corpses.

4. Mountains: steep, gloomy, fog

Fog banks hide the drops, so the floor below is a guess. Rope bridges, cliff shrines, prayer flags, snow, falling rock, a monastery gone quiet.

Foes: harpies or mountain eagles, goat-skulled hermits, Hollowed patrols.

5. The Last Light (border fort)

Act I needs a fifth region for its fifth boss. A border fort at the top of the pass closes the act on the story beat: Piet tells Halden about Ilse here.

Act II: something is off

Act II never jump-scares; it just never lets the player relax. Most of that unease comes from design and sound, not art:

- townsfolk stop working and watch you pass;
- faces repeat, and smiles are slightly too wide;
- bells ring at the wrong times;
- ambient music is detuned a few cents;
- shadows point the wrong way;
- Cassian's portrait is on every wall, and its eyes track you;
- friendly villagers stay friendly until you're close.

1. Villages outside the gates

Harvest festival, bunting, a maypole, everyone smiling. Then a tithe mark on every tenth door.

Foes: corrupted villagers (pitchforks, sickles, flails) who start as idle NPCs and turn when you get close.

2. Slums inside the walls

Mud, rot, maggots, rats, hanging laundry, open sewers.

- **Cutpurses:** the Gilded Debtor reversed. They steal crowns and run; kill them to get the gold back.
- Maggot swarms, rat kings, bloated beggars that burst.
- Plague doctors with rot clouds.

3. The old city

Shops, a market square, signs, a cathedral spire. It's the most normal-looking place in the game, which is the point.

Foes: Hollowed city watch, Tithe-Takers (chain grapples that drag you), Curfew Bellmen (ring for reinforcements), rooftop gargoyles.

4. Royal houses: the most hellish

A feast gone to rot, nobles in masks, portraits that bleed, servants with black eyes, a ballroom of dancers on strings. The devil's touch is strongest near the throne.

Open question: the brief said "just outside the city walls." I'd put them inside, up the hill toward the palace; otherwise the player goes in, comes back out, then goes in again.

5. The palace bridge

The gate of pikes and Ser Gideon. This is the act's fifth region and its ending.

Act III: summoners

Summoners fit a system the game already has: interrupting a wind-up (tactics.js) already pays off.

- **The channel:** cultists kneel in a ring and chant for about 6 seconds, with the wind-up glint showing.
- **Interrupted:** they die cheaply.
- **Not interrupted:** a big demon tears up through the floor and stays.
- **Pairs make it a decision:** kill one and the other restarts the channel.
- **Co-op:** a natural split, "you take the summoners, I'll hold the demon."

Keeping the hell regions distinct

"Same but more hellish" risks five regions that look alike. Give each one dominant element:

Region	Dominant element
Ossuary	Bone
Sold Gaol	Chains over lava
Kiln	Fire
Crypts and sewers	The first cold blue after all the red, telling the player they're climbing out

Before we generate

Generate a cheap mood board first, prove one region in-engine, then make the shippable art.

1. **Decide what the art is for.** A mood board is one key image per region (13 images) to agree the feel. Shippable art is the parallax layers, tilesets and foe sprites. Do the mood board first, then lock a 6–8 colour palette per region from it.
2. **Prove one region in-engine before mass-generating.** The hero and foes are drawn in code at the game's pixel scale. AI pixel art at a different scale can clash badly next to them. Build the swamp end to end (backdrop layers, tiles, two foes) and look at it running before doing the other twelve.
3. **Check credits first.** Thirteen concept images is fine. Thirteen regions of backdrops, tiles and about 25 foes with animation is a real budget, so price it from the account before starting.
4. **Pick the order.** Act I first, in play order, since that's what playtesters see first.

Blocker

SpriteCook and Blueprint Studio are enabled on the account, but their image tools didn't load into the chat where this was planned. Start a new chat in the project; they load at session start. Then ask: "generate the Act I and II mood boards from the story bible."

Open decisions

- [ ] Royal houses inside the walls (up the hill toward the palace) or outside?
- [ ] Desert as the burned ruins of Kesh?
- [ ] Swamp as the first in-engine test region?